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Source: *American Sociological Review*, Jun., 1992, Vol. 57, No. 3 (Jun., 1992), pp. 327-339

Published by: American Sociological Association

Stable URL: <https://www.jstor.org/stable/2096239>

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AFFECTIVE ATTACHMENTS TO NESTED GROUPS: A CHOICE-PROCESS THEORY*

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This paper offers a theory linking choice processes with the experience of transitory emotion and the development of enduring affective attachments to nested collectivities, i.e., subgroups within a larger group, organization, or society. According to the theory, persons become emotionally attached to groups that strengthen their generalized sense of control. The underlying propositions are that: (1) choice processes that foster a high sense of control produce positive emotion (happiness, pride, gratitude); (2) such positive emotion strengthens affective attachments to groups perceived as most responsible for the choice opportunity; and (3) such positive emotion strengthens attachments to proximal subgroups more than to larger, more encompassing collectivities. Complementary predictions obtain for lack of choice, negative emotion (sadness, shame, hostility), and the weakening of collective attachments. The theory explicates a subtle social process important to individual/group relations, and suggests conditions likely to produce behavior directed at the collective welfare.

In this paper, I develop a connection between two simple but far-reaching ideas. The first is that people value self-determination, choice, and discretion. Diverse areas of inquiry — such as theories emphasizing human agency (Giddens 1984), work autonomy (Kohn and Slomczynski 1990), intrinsic motivation (Deci 1975), and “human freedom” (Westcott 1988) — contain such a conceptual thread. The second idea is that people form person-to-collectivity attachments that are theoretically and empirically distinct from person-to-person bonds (Parsons 1951; Kanter 1972; Hall 1988). I analyze theoretically how and when groups, organizations, or societies that provide individuals the most freedom of choice also produce the strongest actor-to-collectivity attachments.

Social structures typically place actors in multiple, nested collectivities in which they are simultaneously members of at least two groups, one encompassed within the other. Examples in-

clude a province within a nation, a clique within a political party, a division within a corporation, a department within a college, a juvenile gang within a neighborhood, or a nuclear family within an extended family. Nested groups are composite, generalized others constituting distinct referential comparisons and identities for individuals. Given such nested groups, under what conditions do actors develop different degrees of attachment to subgroups and the larger group?

Consider the experience of a recent immigrant in an ethnic community within a host country. Upon arrival, the immigrant faces a set of opportunities and constraints regarding housing, employment, and education. To the extent that the local ethnic community provides the immigrant with relevant information, contacts, or resources to shape a range of options, the ethnic community is a primary source of the immigrant’s sense of freedom and control over his or her own fate. The theory predicts stronger attachments to that ethnic community. Attachments to the larger collectivity, the host nation, will be slow to develop to the degree that it erects bureaucratic hurdles that constrain the immigrant’s options.

Parsons (1951) distinguished person-to-person from person-to-collectivity attachments. He argued that the latter are an important foundation for social order once the collective becomes a distinct cognitive object for members. In the above example, immigrants are likely to have interpersonal bonds with persons in the host coun-

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try before migrating and to develop more such ties after arriving. However, immigrants also become part of an ethnic community and are likely to develop some degree of attachment to that community as such. According to Parsons, actor-to-collectivity attachments take three primary forms — cognitive (utilitarian), cathectic (emotional), and evaluative (normative). Each form is important in the overall relationship between personality systems and social systems (Parsons and Shils 1951; Parsons 1951; see also Kanter 1972). Strong bonds on any of these dimensions make actors more responsive to the control and sanction systems of a group, organization, or society. Immigrants who develop strong attachments to the local ethnic community should be more responsive to its norms about how to get along in the host country. Thus, if individual choice is one basis for collective attachments, paradoxically it also is a source of increasing collective control and subjugation of individuals (Lawler forthcoming).

My theory deals with the cathectic form of actor-to-collectivity attachment in order to understand how transitory emotions generated by choice situations produce enduring emotional attachments to nested subgroups. In the abstract choice situation, actors engage in instrumental tasks that can be accomplished in a variety of ways. A social structure, encompassing at least one subgroup and one larger group, shapes actors' options for accomplishing their tasks, and these options have uncertain consequences, difficult to assess objectively. Such a choice situation describes a social context that people encounter frequently and that produces a variety of normal, everyday emotions.

Within such a choice situation, I propose that the *means/ends* choice process weakens or strengthens affective attachments to groups by producing normal, everyday *positive* or *negative* emotional states. Examples of relevant positive emotions are happiness, pride, and gratitude; examples of relevant negative emotions are sadness, shame, and hostility. I exclude from consideration "pathological" or debilitating levels of fear, anger, or depression (see Izard 1977 and Kemper 1987 for relevant discussions) and focus on the choice *process* rather than its consequences (Kemper 1978) or performance outcomes (Weiner, Russell, and Lerman 1979). The choice-to-emotion emphasis differs from recent efforts to understand emotion-to-rational choice links (Isen 1987; Frank 1988; Etzioni 1988).

CONCEPTUAL FRAMEWORK

The Choice Situation

The theory assumes a *choice situation* that confronts actors as group members with a "problem" and with uncertainty about how to solve it. The case of an immigrant to a new country is an extreme example. The uncertainty may concern: (1) what goal or future state of affairs to pursue, e.g., what type of housing to seek; (2) what means are available, e.g., how to find housing; or (3) what consequences are likely, e.g., how adequate will the housing be? Viewed from a rational choice perspective (Elster 1986; Hechter 1987), actors who face a choice situation specify one or more goals, identify alternative means for reaching the goal(s), and assess the likely consequences of each. The chosen act produces a set of external events, e.g., consequences. Thus, the choice situation produces a choice process — means/ends deliberation — that is analytically and empirically distinct from the *chosen act* and from the *events* or external consequences produced by the chosen act.

Most conceptions of decision-making processes portray such choice situations in purely cognitive terms. Yet goals are motivational conditions that arouse emotion as well as cognition and both emotion and cognition affect subsequent goal-directed behavior (Izard 1977). Emotional and cognitive states are intertwined in a choice process, and I hope to disentangle some of the connections among these states.

Concept of Emotion

An *emotion* can be defined as a relatively short term positive or negative evaluative state that involves neurophysiological, neuromuscular, and often cognitive components (Kemper 1978; Izard 1977). Normal emotions are assumed to be relatively mild sensations of feeling good (happy) or feeling bad (sad) (Isen 1987). However, the psychological and sociological literatures on emotion reveal little consensus about the meaning and foundation of "emotion" and related terms, such as affect, mood, feelings, and sentiments (Kemper 1987; Gordon 1981; Izard 1977). I adopt a position similar to Kemper's (1978) and Gordon's (1981) — that *emotion* is a transitory feeling; *affect* is an enduring feeling or sentiment. Furthermore, I treat emotion and mood as synonymous.

The normal emotions important to choice situations entail distinctive bodily changes or sensa-

tions (Kemper 1978) as well as cognitive appraisal — comprehension and interpretation — of the bodily sensations (Lazarus 1984; Schacter and Singer 1962). Extrapolating from the psychological literature, an actor in a choice situation is likely to experience both heightened arousal in the form of “interest-excitement” based on an “awareness of potential satisfaction” (Deci 1975, 1980; Izard 1977) and also fear based on the prospect of being unable to deal with the problem. However, cognition mediates the emotional effects of a choice situation because actors must recognize or comprehend that a problem affecting their well-being exists (see Lazarus 1984 for a related argument). My focus aligns more with arguments for the primacy of cognition and social construction (Schacter and Singer 1962; Shott 1979; Gordon 1981; Lazarus 1984) than with arguments for the primacy of emotion and specific underlying physiological conditions (Kemper 1978; Zajonc 1984).¹

The interest and fear produced by choice situations are baseline emotions that direct actors attention toward a choice problem that results in a choice process and further cognitive appraisal, i.e., means/ends deliberation. For example, new immigrants are likely to experience interest and fear that focuses their attention on issues of housing, employment, and so on. I argue that subsequent choice processes add layers of cognitive appraisal that, in turn, produce other emotions. A choice process can make people feel good, happy, thankful, or relieved, or it can make them feel bad, sad, angry, hostile, or tense. In a choice situation, cognitions mediate all of these emotions. The emotions in turn tend to produce an attribution process as actors singly or jointly attempt to understand the source of the emotion. For actors, developing a common sense understanding of why they feel the way they do is important so they can reproduce good feelings and avoid bad feelings in the future.

The theory I propose takes happiness, pride, and gratitude as the most relevant positive emotions, and sadness, shame, and hostility as corresponding negative emotions.² Most important for

my theory is whether a choice process produces positive versus negative emotion rather than any specific type of emotion. Thus, assuming a choice situation that produces some combination of interest and fear leading to a choice process, my theory examines how resulting cognitive responses (1) yield general positive or negative feelings (happiness or sadness) that in turn (2) foster enduring affective attachments toward nested groups.³

BASIC PROPOSITIONS

Social Structure and the Choice Process

Choice situations occur in a social structure that creates a set of options (means) and legitimized goals (ends). Rational choice theory views social structure primarily as a constraint that establishes a “set of feasible options” ranked in terms of an actor’s preference (Hechter 1987; Elster 1986). Elster’s synopsis of a rational choice process, however, implies that social structure not only constrains choice, but also “frees” action by providing more than one option. Adopting a similar theme, Giddens (1984) developed the idea that any social structure has both “constraining” and “enabling” effects on social action or choice.

“Enabling” echoes Kanter’s (1977) “empowerment.” For example, she stressed that job enrichment programs that increase task variety are not likely to increase a worker’s commitment to a company unless such programs include structural changes giving the worker more options and autonomy; otherwise, job enrichment increases the “burdens” or constraints, counteracting

self (Kemper 1978), gratitude and hostility to others (individuals or collectivities). While Kemper treats happiness, depression, fear, and anger as primary emotions and pride, shame, gratitude as secondary, my theory treats sadness as normal, everyday depression and integrates fear and interest/excitement into the choice situation (Izard 1977). Anger is incorporated as hostility toward external sources of sadness, i.e., as a secondary rather than a primary emotion in Kemper’s terms.

³ Empirical efforts to dimensionalize emotion vocabularies and moods invariably generate positive/negative factors, such as happy/sad or pleasant/unpleasant (Watson and Tellegen 1985; Clore, Ortong, and Foss 1987; MacKinnon and Keating 1989). Arousal or activation is a second dimension that typically emerges and potency is a third, somewhat less important dimension, suggested by research using Osgood’s semantic differential approach to meaning (Heise 1988; MacKinnon and Keating 1989).

¹ I make no general claim about the primacy of emotion versus cognition (see debate between Zajonc 1984 and Lazarus 1984), but assume that emotions created by a choice situation involve some degree of cognitive mediation.

² Happiness and sadness are diffuse positive and negative feelings elicited by the choice process, whereas the other emotions are, by definition, more specific and attach to social objects — pride and shame to the

potential benefits of increased task variety (Kanter 1978, pp. 256–57). Related research on organizations suggests the importance of work autonomy and discretion for satisfaction, commitment, and turnover (e.g., Mathieu and Zajac 1990).

The constraining and enabling effects of social structure are two sides of the same coin. Actors interpret a social structure primarily in terms of either the *constraints* it imposes or what it *enables* them to do. This interpretation can be characterized as the actor's "sense of control," the perception that she or he can cause external events, that is, manipulate the environment (Westcott 1988). I argue that means/ends deliberation in the choice process is an important foundation for such perceptions and, thus, for the generalized sense of control fostered by a social structure. Means/ends deliberation occurs in the context of a given social structure and, therefore, choice processes are one of several mediators between structural conditions and an actor's sense of control.

The socially defined "option set" that constrains or enables the choice process forges a link between the social structure and the actors' choice of a specific act. I conceptualize the option set as partly exogenous (dictated by the structure) and partly endogenous (shaped by means/end deliberation). To the degree that actors construct socially defined options, they sense high control over the choice. From this perspective, complex tasks undertaken without much supervision create a high sense of control (Kohn and Slomczynski 1990) because actors' "occupational self-direction" permits them to develop and reshape options, that is, engage in more means/ends deliberation. Examples include a faculty member determining how to teach a course, a computer engineer deciding how to develop a particular computer program, and a middle manager deciding how best to implement a change in organizational policy mandated by upper management. Position in the stratification system determines the degree to which work conditions, like closeness of supervision, allow self-direction that, in turn, produces a general orientation (personality) toward self-direction and intellectual flexibility (Kohn and Slomczynski 1990). When the social structure, e.g., a position or role, fixes the options, actors may still "freely" evaluate the option set and perceive themselves as controlling the choice within the set. In this case, the range of options may be the most important determinant of an actor's sense of control rather than the actor's capacity to shape them. This reasoning implies:

Proposition 1: If the choice processes provided by a social structure increase an actor's range of options or discretion to revise options, then the actor's generalized sense of control will increase.

Several properties of the option set can produce variation in the sense of control. Proshansky, Ittelson, and Rivlin (1970) stress the number of options, arguing that more options in a task-oriented setting provide actors greater flexibility to adapt to intricacies of the social context. One series of experiments by Harvey, Harris, and Lightner indicated that actors who face two options with uncertain consequences perceived themselves as having more control if both options had a positive expected value and if the difference between the options was neither very small nor very large (Harvey, Harris, and Lightner 1979; Westcott 1988). By implication, a choice process fosters a low sense of control when the differences among options imply little need for means/ends deliberation and when the choice is among negatively valued options. If new immigrants have only bad housing to choose from or if the choice is between obviously bad and obviously good housing, they will sense less control over where they live than if the choice were among several good housing possibilities. Thus, the socially-defined option set serves as a phenomenological indicator of control for actors in a choice situation.

The Sense of Control and Emotion

A key idea in the psychological literature is that people seek and respond with positive emotion to conditions that give them a "sense of control." Research has shown that actions demonstrating an actor's control, efficacy, self-determination, or mastery over the environment produce positive emotions like pleasure, happiness, and enjoyment (Deci 1975; Izard 1977; Kemper 1978). White (1959) tied this propensity to an "effec-tance motivation," i.e., exploration and manipulation of the environment, that is neurological in origin. Deci (1975, 1980) viewed the need for competence, self-determination, or efficacy as a generalized motivational force that underlies goal-directed behavior and, especially related to my theory, makes goal-directed behavior intrinsically valuable. A variety of other psychological work suggests that a sense of control generates emotional reactions: the theory of psychological reactance (Brehm 1966), attribution the-

ory (Jones and Nisbett 1972), and Rotter's (1966) analysis of internal versus external control. The implication is that the need for self-determination and efficacy produces positive emotions when the choice process realizes this need and produces negative emotions when the choice process blocks it.

Some sociological work also supports the importance of self-determination or efficacy, e.g., Giddens' (1984) structuration theory, Marx's ([1932] 1964) analysis of worker alienation from the products of their labor, and Kohn's research on class and work autonomy (Kohn and Slomczynski 1990). In an interesting application, Marwell (1966) conceptualized the illegal acts of juvenile delinquents as efforts to demonstrate their ability to control or to manipulate situations despite their lack of resources (skills, wealth, etc.). Properties of delinquent acts, such as "negativism" and "maliciousness," reflect the intrinsic value of claiming or asserting control even if punishments are inevitable. Eliciting punishment is evidence of an impact on the world and is valued and approved by peers because it affirms the potential for control or power. A similar point is implied by Goffman's (1961) analysis of how persons in total institutions carve out areas of freedom and subtle resistance that give them a sense of control over some part of their lives.

Thus, from a diverse literature, I assume that: (1) as "agents" in their social world, humans value a sense of control; (2) they experience a sense of control when social structures enable them to manipulate the external world, i.e., to generate a "product" individually or jointly; (3) the "production" process, as well as its result, is a basis for actors' inferences of generalized freedom or control (or lack of it); and (4) actors react emotionally as well as cognitively to their sense of freedom and control. This implies:

Proposition 2: If a choice process (means/ends deliberation) within a social structure reaffirms or increases an actor's sense of control, then an actor experiences positive emotions (e.g., happiness, pride, or gratitude); if a choice process reaffirms or increases a lack of control, then an actor experiences negative emotions (e.g., sadness, shame, or hostility).

"Perceived freedom of choice" is substitutable for "sense of control" in the above proposition (see Deci 1975, 1980 on "intrinsic motivation," and White 1959 on "effectance motivation"). Choices perceived as "free" demonstrate qualities like

self-determination and control to oneself and to others, even if consequences are negative (Marwell 1966; Westcott 1988).⁴

The choice process is important independent of the consequences of choice because it reflects an actor's capacity to adapt, initiate, and explore in future choice situations. Although actors may prefer to avoid a choice situation in the first place, once confronted, they prefer more choice to less choice. Avoiding choices means avoiding the uncertainty associated with choice situations; it does not mean seeking less freedom or control when facing uncertainty. Also, inferences from the choice process shape emotional responses to the consequences of choice. If the choice process creates an impression of free choice, then actors infer that they can maintain "good" consequences or stem "bad" consequences in future choices. Therefore, the emotional effects of the sense of control do not depend solely on the consequences of a choice as Kemper's (1978) theory suggests.⁵

Kemper's (1978) sociological theory of emotion suggested that the control actors derive from social structure engenders emotion. However, he ignored the role of the choice process and stressed the emotional effects of whether an actor's power or status in a relationship is excessive, adequate, or insufficient (Kemper 1978, 1990). Excessive or insufficient power/status levels produce negative emotions (e.g., guilt, shame) while adequate levels produce positive emotions (e.g.,

⁴ The theoretical and empirical foundations for equating "sense of control" and "perceived freedom of choice" are primarily studies of Western cultures. Although the cultural definitions and content of choice and freedom probably differ across cultures, the abstract principles of my theory should be broadly, if not universally, applicable. The question of cross-cultural validity is, of course, an important empirical issue.

⁵ Evidence of control arising from the choice process should enhance the positive emotions generated by good consequences, but dampen the negative emotions associated with bad consequences because actors still perceive the *potential* for control (see Marwell 1966 for an application regarding juvenile delinquency, and Pyszczynski and Greenberg 1987 on post-decision biases). The dampening of negative emotions can be accentuated by dissonance effects, but this requires a perception that the negative consequences were foreseeable. Research reveals that dissonance effects occur *only* if a freely-made choice is *counter-attitudinal* and has *negative consequences* that should have been *foreseen* by the actor (Pyszczynski and Greenberg 1987).

happiness and security). If social structure is interpreted in terms of status, Kemper's (1978, 1987, 1990) theory makes predictions similar to mine on the happiness and sadness dimensions (Kemper 1990, p. 222).⁶

My theory diverges from Kemper's (1978) primarily in that I treat the sense of control as a generalized potential that is independent of particular control-related outcomes (see also Marwell 1966). Thus, "power" in Kemper's theory is realized or actual power, whereas in my theory "power" is a *potential* (Bacharach and Lawler 1981). With the latter position, presumably there is no upper threshold beyond which control and mastery foster guilt or shame. People may feel guilt or shame for exercising excessive control over others in a particular situation, as Kemper (1987) suggested, but also feel good about their potential to control future uncertainties. My theory stipulates that, *ceteris paribus*, any increase in perceptions of potential control produces positive emotion.

From Propositions 1 and 2, I can refine Collins' (1975, 1981) insightful analysis of stratification and emotional energy. He argued that actors ranked high in a hierarchy build up reserves of emotional energy because they often "give orders" and thus develop strong feelings of self assurance and confidence. Those low in the hierarchy tend to "take orders," which dampens confidence and fosters fatalism (Collins 1975, Chap. 2). In contrast, my theory indicates that the positive emotion produced by "giving orders" depends on the degree of perceived choice about what orders to give; similarly, the negative feeling produced by "taking orders" depends on the degree of choice about taking orders or options for refusing them (e.g., appeals, grievances). Formalized rules, for example, can constrain the "giving" of orders as much as the "taking" of orders. If the process of giving or taking orders does not foster perceptions of freedom to shape and decide among options, Collins' proposition, that confidence and emotional energy would be enhanced, should not obtain.

⁶ In Kemper's (1978, 1990) theory, the particular negative emotion produced by insufficient or excessive power/status depends on whether the self or other is deemed responsible for the power/status situation. My theory adds positive emotion to Kemper's (1978) "own agency" condition and negative emotion to the "other agency" condition, given the intrinsic value of potential mastery, self-determination, and control (Deci 1975).

Combining Propositions 1 and 2, then, *social structures* are important because they produce repeated choice situations in which actors increase or decrease their senses of control. When formal or informal positions, standard operating procedures, or interpersonal pressures highly constrain choice processes, actors experience frequent reminders of minimal control and negative emotions result. Such constraining social structures weaken affective attachments to relevant groups. In contrast, social structures that create repeated instances of perceived choice and control (real or not) generate positive emotions that strengthen affective attachments to relevant groups. The repeated experience of positive or negative emotions that social structures create is the basis for cognitive (attributional) appraisals that underlie enduring affective attachments to nested subgroups and/or collectivities.⁷

CHOICE AND COLLECTIVE ATTACHMENTS

I propose that actors understand and explain their levels of control with reference to the nested collectivities occasioning choices. Not all collectivities or groups are salient in choice situations, but among those that are salient my theoretical argument deals with (1) how actors perceive each group's responsibility for choice opportunities, (2) what socially constructed rules shape their allocation of affective attachments across larger groups and nested subgroups, and (3) how choice processes generate affective attachments and in turn promote behavior directed toward the collective welfare of nested groups.

The Responsibility Principle

Interacting actors are likely to develop common sense rules that indicate implicitly which collectivities are the primary fountainheads of human agency, freedom, and choice. These collectivities may range from entire societies to large or-

⁷ Isen's (1987) review of social psychological evidence on everyday feelings suggested that affective attachments to groups, organizations, or societies can develop from everyday emotional experiences. She indicated that positive emotion makes people more sociable, cooperative, and helpful and suggested that positive feeling leads actors to "see less distinction between themselves and others or see themselves and others . . . as parts of a larger whole." (p. 242). My theory posits that the development of such group attachments is mediated by a cognitive process.

ganizations to small local groups or subgroups. Common sense rules may be embedded in socially validated myths about the primary extra-individual powers in the social world, the empowering effects of local and more distant collectivities, or the conditions of human agency (i.e., concepts of individualism). In fact, collective myths may transform objective constraint into subjective feelings of empowerment, as illustrated by cults that produce *both* complete submission and high (voluntary) commitment.

The *responsibility principle* extends my Propositions 1 and 2; it stipulates that those subgroups or groups perceived to be the most empowering enjoy the strongest affective attachments. For example, if an ethnic community has well-developed institutions for aiding new immigrants, enhancing their choices of housing, jobs, and so forth, those institutions will strengthen affective attachments to the ethnic community. The ethnic community is likely to be more salient to immigrants, and interaction within the community would tend to generate beliefs about its empowering effects. To the degree that the larger nation or society imposes bureaucratic or political constraints on immigrants' options, their affective ties to the larger society or nation will be weakened. Thus:

Proposition 3: Among salient collectivities, positive emotion generated by choice processes strengthens affective ties to collectivities credited with making the choice opportunities available; negative emotion weakens ties to collectivities blamed for limiting choice.

The explanatory scope of Proposition 3 is illustrated by Watkins' (1991) demographic analysis of Western Europe between 1870 to 1960. She showed that marital and fertility rates across local (i.e., "provincial") communities within the same nation converged over time. Her explanation for the growing impact of national boundaries emphasized that states became more important sources of economic and political opportunity than smaller, local communities. In terms of my theory, if citizens view the state as the primary source of empowerment in the form of new social, economic, and political options and rights, then states become more important sources of positive emotion and are subject to stronger affective attachments. Thus, my theory may help explain the influence of the state on marital/fertility behavior across provincial communities (Watkins 1991).

The cognitive underpinnings of the responsibility principle involve an attribution "*once removed*," i.e., a "second-order" attribution. Attribution theory examines inferences from the success or failure of a chosen act (Pyszczynski and Greenberg 1987), whereas I focus on inferences elicited by the choice process. In contrast to attribution theory, at issue is not whether actors view choice consequences as internally or externally caused (Jones and Nisbett 1972; Weiner et al. 1979), but which social groups they hold responsible for their choice opportunities.

Whether choice consequences are perceived as internally or externally caused, actors have a common sense, socially-validated explanation for the presence or absence of choice opportunities. For example, a worker with high autonomy may use the autonomy effectively and credit himself or herself, in accord with attribution theory, but that worker also has a common sense understanding of what groups are responsible for the autonomy. Crediting groups that provide choice opportunities does not necessarily undermine causal attributions for the consequences of a chosen act, but it does provide a basis for stronger attachments to the responsible collectivity.⁸

To summarize, actors share a common sense understanding of the sources of choice opportunity; they trace such opportunities through a second-order attribution process to salient (nested) collectivities or groups; groups or collectivities perceived as most responsible for enabling choice receive credit, while those responsible for constraining choice receive blame; and affective attachments to a nested or larger collectivity are strengthened or weakened in proportion to the credit or blame.

The Distribution Principle

How do actors distribute affective attachments to local subgroups versus more distant collectiv-

⁸ Causal attributions can affect the prominence of specific emotions like pride versus shame or gratitude versus hostility. Some research on internal versus external attributions of success/failure suggests that a result perceived as internally-caused creates *self-directed* pride or shame (See Weiner et al. 1979), whereas an external attribution fosters *other-directed* gratitude or hostility. The "second-order" attribution process assumed by my theory remains, but Proposition 3 warrants some qualification if choice processes that produce pride or shame affect attachments to collectivities differently than choice processes that foster gratitude or hostility. This is an empirical question.

ities? According to the responsibility principle, the distribution of affective attachments stems from actors' attributions of responsibility for emotions produced repeatedly in choice processes. However, actors are likely to be biased in favor of one group or another in part because emotional resources are scarce enough to require allocation (Collins 1981). Actors' emotions tend to be finite, whereas the social objects to which they can be directed are virtually unlimited (Hammond 1983; Collins 1975, 1981). Furthermore, both a subgroup nested within a larger group and the larger group itself constitute distinct referents and sources of identity, e.g., the local ethnic community and larger society for an immigrant. Developing differential attachments to each collectivity forestalls confusion, ambivalence, and indecision when options have a differential impact on the subgroup versus the larger group. Thus, actors form different degrees of attachment to the multiple, nested collectivities of which they are members.

The process of allocating affective ties is socially "managed" by actors in the same general sense that feelings are managed to fit the social structure (Hochschild 1983). That is, just as "rules" specify what emotions to feel and when to express them (Hochschild 1983), socially constructed rules for crediting or blaming collectivities likewise inhere in a choice situation. One plausible rule allocates credit to local, more immediate collectivities, and another credits larger, more encompassing collectivities. Each rule probably reflects the salience of larger cultural myths or locally-created myths about the sources of human agency. These basic rules, termed proximal and distal, embody actors' implicit understandings of their agency and exemplify the role attributed to collectivities.

Based on the *proximal rule*, actors develop stronger affective ties to subgroups within a social system rather than to the social system, to local communities rather than to states, to work groups rather than to the work organization, and so forth. Larger collectivities that foster choice and freedom among members still enhance positive actor-to-collectivity affective bonds, but less so than those to the nested subgroups. This means, for example, that the empowering effects of corporate decentralization will strengthen affective ties to local work units more than to the corporation (Kanter 1977, pp. 276–77).

There are good reasons for believing that a proximal rule is common. A collectivity that is close or immediately present, such as a group of

friends with a common endeavor, will be more salient than other collectivities of which the group is a part. Furthermore, because highly proximate groups are also those with whom the actor interacts face-to-face, they should heavily influence the development and maintenance of shared definitions of choice opportunities, referential standards, and the like. Collins's (1981) theory of interaction ritual chains suggested a proximity principle because "conversations" are the ultimate locus for emotional energy.

In some important cases, a proximal rule exerts pressure toward fragmentation of the larger organization, community, or society. The reassertion of strong ethnic identification in contemporary European societies is one example, Marwell's (1966) interpretation of juvenile delinquency is another. Individual action as a juvenile gang member is a mechanism for youths with few resources to claim autonomy and demonstrate, according to their own normative standards, an impact on an unresponsive adult world. A stronger affective attachment to the subgroup in this case relates to a negative attachment to the larger group. Antagonism between a nested group and a larger group may occur in part because a proximal rule for interpreting sources of empowerment is intertwined with a distal rule for interpreting sources of constraint.

A *distal rule* simply inverts the proximal rule: The more distant, remote, and all-encompassing collectivity is the primary source of individual empowerment or constraint. Choice processes that generate positive emotion will strengthen emotional ties to the larger collectivity more than to the smaller subgroups nested within it. This rule assumes that the salience of the larger group is greater than the salience of the subgroup, in part because actors perceive the larger group's involvement and interest in subgroup activities. A distal rule is especially likely when the larger group closely monitors or regulates subgroups (Hechter 1987), when collective rituals and symbols are frequent enough to make the larger collectivity highly salient (Collins 1975), and when social transformations create larger social units from smaller ones (Watkins 1991). When it comes to salience, however, local, more immediate subgroups have a decided advantage.

Use of the proximal rule for positive emotion and the distal rule for negative emotion is contingent on whether the subgroup or larger group is more salient to actors. Proximal subgroups are typically most salient because frequent face-to-face interaction enables subgroups to mediate the

control messages of the larger collectivity and to shift responsibility for perceived low choice to the larger collective and of perceived high choice to the nested subgroup. Thus:

Proposition 4: Given that nested subgroups are more salient to an actor than are larger groups, positive emotion produced by choice processes strengthens affective attachments to a nested subgroup more than to its larger group; negative emotion weakens affective attachments to the larger group more than to the nested subgroup.

The structural connections between the subgroup and larger group should affect the strength of the distribution rule. *The proximal rule for positive emotion and the distal rule for negative emotion will be stronger in more decentralized structures.* Decentralized or flat structures are composed of subgroups “loosely coupled” to each other and to the larger whole, a university being the prototype (Weick 1976; Meyer and Rowan 1977). Nested subgroups in such structures have substantial autonomy and are subject to minimal monitoring. Kanter’s (1977) case study of a corporation suggested that the empowering of middle managers by involving them more in planning and policy also empowers their subordinates if the manager’s greater involvement in planning leaves subordinates more discretion over day-to-day matters. Given such mutual empowerment, superordinates and subordinates have the “common cause” of protecting their local autonomy, which from my theory will accentuate the tendency to credit subgroups for their choice opportunities or autonomy and blame the larger collectivity for constraints.

From my theory, “loosely-coupled” (decentralized) structures foster choice processes that reaffirm actors’ sense of control (Proposition 1) and thereby produce more positive emotion (Proposition 2). Subgroups in decentralized structures are more salient than the larger group, are accorded more credit for high choice (Proposition 3), and are the objects of stronger affective ties than is the larger group (Proposition 4). The more decoupled the nested subgroup is from the larger group, the greater the difference between members’ affective attachments to the subgroup versus the larger group. Overall, the theory points to some fundamental problems that decentralized organizations face in creating among members a commitment to the organization as a whole.

While the theory indicates how individual choice processes make nested subgroups a stron-

ger magnet for collective attachments, it also suggests how larger groups sometimes counteract this tendency. Consider Tilly’s (1990) argument that European states, unlike cities, developed more from the use of coercion (e.g., armed force, incarceration, expropriation) than from the use of capital (i.e., the accumulation, sale, and purchase of tangible resources). Taking coercion as constraint and capital as empowering, Proposition 4 indicates that cities will elicit stronger affective attachments than states and will remain an important source of fragmentation following state formation. Affective ties to states, however, can strengthen over time as states become the primary sources of the growing social, economic, and political options and opportunities (Watkins 1991). Thus, my theory shows how the differences in affective attachments to cities versus states may decline over time and may even become stronger objects of attachment than cities.

In fact, highly centralized systems should produce distal rules for positive emotion if collective myths associate individual empowerment with high levels of group control. In this case, an actor’s sense of control is mediated by and vicariously experienced through membership in a strong, all-encompassing collective. Nazism’s characterization of the German Reich, for example, involved collective myths that connected individual submission to the state with state-mediated individual empowerment. Cults often foster myths that provide vicarious agency via submission to the collective. Under more typical conditions, however, decentralized and centralized structures will lead to subtly different myths about empowerment that simply attenuate or accentuate the differences in attachment specified by Proposition 4 without reversing the pattern.

COLLECTIVE ATTACHMENTS AND RITUAL BEHAVIOR

Collective attachments should affect action independent of other well-known social psychological or sociological processes, such as conformity, interpersonal attraction, monitoring, sanction systems, and so forth (Drescher, Burlingame, and Fuhrman 1985; Hechter 1987; Kaplan 1989). Isolating the effects of the collective as an object of perception unto itself (Durkheim 1954; Parsons 1951; Tajfel and Turner 1986; Markovsky and Lawler 1989) is important to explanations of social order because collective attachments may buttress the impact of “corporate obligations” on individual members (Hechter 1987), enhance the

zealotry produced by interpersonal rewards in nested subgroups (Coleman 1987), or make public goods symbols of the group or collectivity. I posit a simple process that creates such effects, drawing on Sen's (1973, 1977) critique of the single preference-order assumption of rational choice theory and Collin's (1975, 1981) behavioral conception of ordinary, everyday "ritual" (also see Wuthnow 1987).

Sen (1973, 1977) argued that actors in choice situations have multiple preference orderings that reflect different goals, values, or priorities. Therefore, choice process involves choosing among alternative preference sets (i.e., metapreferences) in addition to making a choice within a given preference set. An actor in nested groups may choose between a preference set stressing the collective welfare or one stressing individual welfare, and simultaneously between the preference set of a subgroup or a larger group. In my theory, the choice between the preferences of the subgroup and larger group becomes a variable to be explained. From Propositions 1 through 4, as collective attachments become stronger, actors individual welfare metapreferences shift toward the collective welfare, and the welfare of nested subgroups is given priority over that of the larger group for the same reasons that proximal distribution rules are more likely. Thus:

Proposition 5: Given that nested subgroups are more salient to an actor than larger groups, repeated affirmations of control or "freedom" within the choice process increase the probability of an actor adopting preference orders based on the proximal group's welfare.

The role of *repetitive* choice process (means/ends deliberation) in a social structure suggests that as choice processes make collective attachments stronger, the collective attachments in turn transform choice processes into ritual affirmations of the collective. This idea is extracted from recent treatments of ritual as normal, everyday repetitive behaviors that express or symbolize common group memberships (Wuthnow 1987; Collins 1975, 1981, 1989). Forms of everyday ritual can range, for example, from the use of the pronoun "we" or other subtle acknowledgments of groupness (Goffman 1967) to self-sacrificing action that publicly promotes the collective welfare. Ritual behavior is based partly on "taken-for-granted" realities associated with a collective and its members. Metapreferences exemplify a taken-for-granted reality on which certain pref-

erence sets are routinely selected over others, which implies that ritual behavior frames but does not eliminate choice (see Wuthnow 1987 for a similar point).⁹

Given the role of repetitive choice, the central features of Collins's (1981, 1989) theory of "interaction ritual chains" suggest that the priority of collective welfare metapreferences grows based on the links between the choice process, transitory emotion, and affective attachment to collectivities. First, choice processes repeatedly focus group members' attention on a common problem, i.e., uncertainty. Second, the choice processes make actors aware of their common focus and make salient their common membership in a nested subgroup and a larger group. Third, the choice processes generate positive emotion that members publicly display and attribute to salient subgroups or larger groups. Fourth, actors strive to maintain the positive emotion that the choice processes generate, which leads them to take more account of the group perceived as most responsible for the positive emotion. The adoption of the group welfare metapreference becomes an everyday ritual or routine and an actor's sense of control derives primarily from the choice options within this metapreference.

To summarize, my theory suggests (1) how the impact of choice processes on collective attachments can lead to ritual adoption of collective metapreferences, (2) why the metapreferences of nested subgroups are likely to be chosen over those of the larger group, and (3) how choice processes within a given metapreference can reaffirm actors' sense of control, create related emotions, and strengthen further collective attachments. Means/ends deliberation in a choice process can both reaffirm actors' sense of control (by providing good options within a given metapreference) and express or symbolize the collective (by taking for granted the group-welfare metapreference). In this manner, freedom and constraint work hand-in-hand to foster stronger collective attachments.

⁹ Wuthnow (1987) hypothesized that ritual behavior is particularly frequent and strong when members of a collectivity face uncertainty. Ritual behavior reduces uncertainty by invoking shared realities (see also Collins 1981) and fostering collective myths that dramatize actors' moral obligations. Interestingly, conditions that generate ritual behavior, i.e., environmental uncertainties, are strikingly similar to those that initiate choice processes. The "choice" of metapreference may be a particularly important form of ritual in choice situations.

CONCLUSION

In this paper, I specify links between individual choice and collective attachment that capture a common thread underlying issues of control and autonomy in groups, organizations, and societies. To give discretion, to empower, and to delegate is to alter actors' option sets in ways that arouse transitory positive feelings when a choice opportunity occurs. The central point is that emotions produced in choice processes help account for actors' affective attachments to multiple, nested collectivities of which they are members. Insofar as choice processes give actors the impression (real or not) of "free choice" and they attribute this to a given collectivity, their affective attachments to that collectivity strengthen; insofar as choice processes give actors the impression of little freedom of choice and they attribute this to a given collectivity, affective attachments to that collectivity weaken.

My theory suggests that groups, organizations, or societies that generate and maintain "free choice" induce more ritual compliance on behalf of the collective welfare than is indicated by underlying conditions of "individualism." Positive feelings repeatedly produced by a sense of freedom and control shift metapreferences toward the collective welfare; negative feelings stimulated repeatedly by little freedom and control shift metapreferences toward actors' own welfare or toward the welfare of another group. To the degree that the adoption of subgroup metapreference becomes an everyday routine or ritual, the choice process comes to symbolize that group. This gives social legitimacy to both the adoption of the group metapreference and the freedom to choose among options within it. Thus, I conceptualize actor-to-collectivity relations as a tacit bargain in which collectivities provide some freedom of choice to actors who, in return, shift metapreferences toward the collective welfare and redefine their individual interests in these terms. To the extent that collective attachments mediate this tacit exchange, freedom of choice becomes a basis for voluntary submission to the norms of one or more collectivities.

By highlighting the intrinsic value of perceived freedom within a means/ends choice process, my theory bridges rational and emotional features of social action. Rational choice theory neglects the intrinsic value to actors of autonomy or control (Sen and Williams 1982), primarily because of its emphasis on consequences and the cognitive underpinning of choice. My theory shows a way

to incorporate the emotional effects of autonomy, self-determination, and control into a rational choice framework. "Sets of feasible options" (Elster 1986) are one basis for actors' inferences of control over uncertainty, and the sense of control has important emotional results that, under certain conditions, enhance the tendency of actors to define their choices in terms of the collective interest. My theory complements recent efforts of rational choice theorists (Coleman 1986; Hechter, Opp, and Wippler 1990) by showing how the process of rational choice may strengthen affective attachments that buttress normative control.

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